



wearing face masks on advice from their head physiologist, for which they later apologised. Foreign TV crews give gleeful half-hourly updates on pollution levels in Beijing. American swimmer, Dara "Supermom" Torres, in her sixth Olympics, while trying to praise the Games' Village, revealed she had brought a sheet and pillow along but was surprised to find the bed linen provided was, "just like the Marriott".

It is presumptuous to pretend to un-

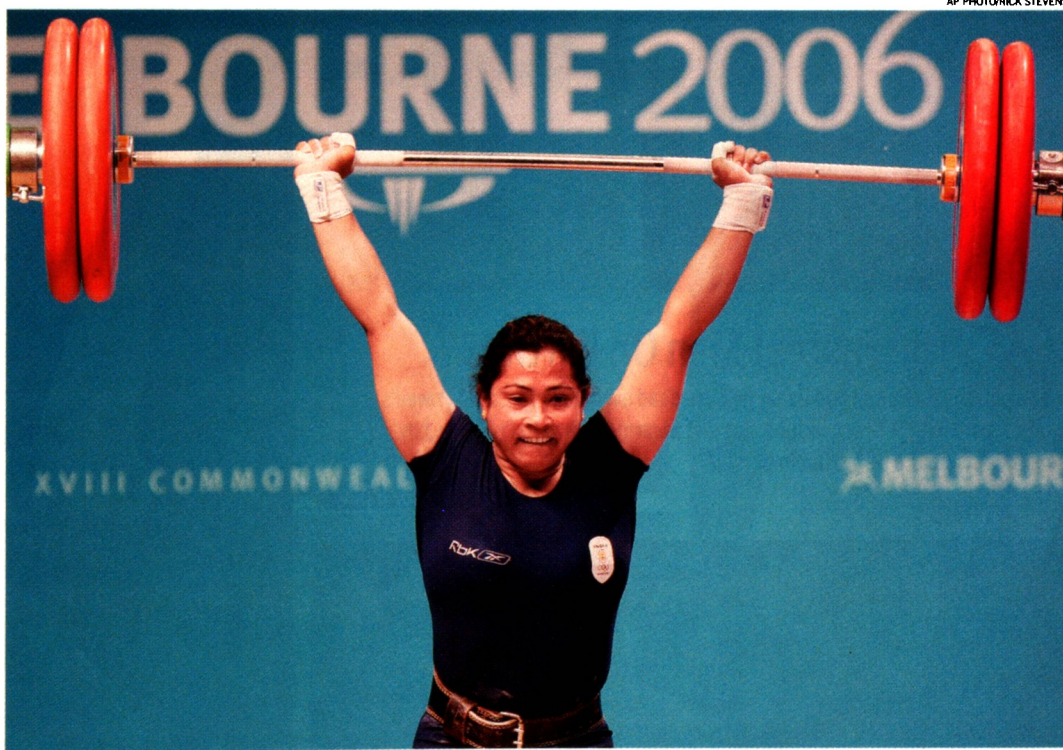
want, says Dr Susan Brownell, expert on Chinese sport and Fulbright scholar, is simple, "They want to be respected as a strong country in the world—it is almost as if they don't believe how strong they are—the problem is in their own eyes." Beijing Olympics is expected to fill in the details of China's hazy portrait of itself.

An 'overseas Chinese' scholar, Guo Ting wonders whether that can happen to a country which loves but at another level internalises 'luan', a mess so dense

time during the Cultural Revolution being "re-educated" in the countryside and were far from ideal patriot material. The Beijing Olympics have, however, triggered a sense of national ambition she can scarcely understand.

She sits in the Jackie Chan Tea & Coffee Bar talking about the country she knows and can still find unknowable. Crowds clutching branded shopping bags are moving through a mall past the local Starbucks. Yet outdoors, people

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AP PHOTORICK STEVENS



CRASHED DREAMS:
Weightlifter Monica
Devi failed a dope test
and was pulled out of
the Beijing Games

derstand a nation's idea of itself after a few days spent about stumbling through a landscape that is as Asian as it is foreign. Some Chinese believe that the country's Olympic yearning is a disconcerting mirror. Sports historian Xu Guoqi writes, "A nation that obsesses over gold medals is not a self-assured nation." China's idea of itself is at odds with how the world sees it: monolithic, autocratic, robotic behemoth to the West and orderly, much-envied eastern neighbour to India. What the Chinese

cannot be cleaned up. Schoolchildren packed in extra hours every day to make up for Olympic holidays. Two Olympic songs were played over the speaker system in the school between lessons, and in shops and supermarkets; speech competitions were organised for ages 6-16 around the themes of 'How I Would Make China Better For The Games'.

But Guo stumbled upon the most intense engagement with the Beijing Olympics where she least expected it. Her scientist grandparents had spent

are still strolling in their pyjamas ignoring government diktats to smarten up. Some bring folding stools and sit fanning themselves on pavements lit up by sushi and tapas bars.

The Olympic makeover has been all too quick, maybe people are still dizzy from change and things are a little blurred. Or maybe Guo is right. She is referring to Beijing, but could be talking of a deeper constancy beyond one shiny Olympic fortnight: "Everywhere else but here it's still China."